

Two Little Soldiers

→ Guy de Maupassant

• Understanding the text

* Answer these Questions.

a) Why do the two soldiers spend their free time on Sundays away from the barracks out in the countryside?

Ans The countryside reminds the soldiers of their rural hometown in Brittany. Living in the sterile, grey army barracks make them homesick, so they seek out a landscape that mirrors the fields and fresh air of their past. By sitting in the grass and eating their lunch outdoors, they feel a temporary sense of peace and a connection to their roots, which helps them endure the monotony of their military service.

b) Why does the girl become the topic of conversation for these soldiers?

Ans The girl becomes their main topic because she is the only person they see during their weekly escapes. To these two lonely soldiers, she represents a touch of home and beauty. Since they are shy and don't talk to anyone else, watching her bring her cow to the

pasture gives them something to look forward to. she becomes a shared dream that brightens their quiet, repetitive lives.

Qc) Why does deception enter into their friendship?

Ans Deception starts when Luc begins sneaking away to see her without telling Jean. Originally the two friends did everything together, but Luc decides to visit the girl during the week in secret. By keeping his romance a secret, he breaks the trust and "brotherhood" they shared. This silence turns their simple friendship into a situation where one friend is being used while other pursues a private goal.

d) Do you think that Luc is a betrayer of friendship?

Ans Yes, Luc is a betrayer because he was not honest with his best friend. Instead of telling Jean that he liked the girl, he went behind his back to win her heart. Friendship is built on being open, but Luc choose to be sneaky. By the time Jean found out, Luc had already "stolen" the girl they both liked, leaving Jean feeling completely pushed out and ~~ign~~ ignored by his closest companion.

e) What is the cause of suicide of Jean?

Do you think that it was the only release of his love?

Ans. Jean killed himself because he felt totally alone and betrayed. He lost the girl he loved, but more importantly, he lost the trust of his best friend. For a simple man like Jean, his friendship with Luc was his whole world. When that bond broke, he felt he had nothing left to live for. In his deep sadness, jumping into the river seemed like the only way to stop his pain.

• Reference to the content

a) What is the central theme of the story?

Ans. The central theme of the story is the shattering of a deep friendship due to jealousy and betrayal. While the two soldiers share a peaceful, silent bond rooted in their common background, the introduction of a romantic interest creates a rivalry that their friendship cannot survive.

At first, their weekly trips to the countryside are a way to escape the loneliness of military life. However, when Luc begins secretly meeting the milk-

aid behind Jean's back, the dynamic shifts from companionship to deception. Jean feels a profound sense of isolation and heartbreak as he realizes his best friend has ~~excluded~~ excluded him from this new part of his life.

Ultimately, the story highlights how emotional betrayal can be more painful than physical harm. The tragic ending shows that when trust is broken between two people who rely on each other, the resulting despair can lead to devastating consequences.

b)

i) Who is the speaker?

Ans The dairymaid (or milkmaid) is the speaker.

ii) What does the word "here" indicate?

Ans "Here" indicates the wooded countryside spot where the soldiers spend their Sundays to escape military life.

iii) Who does "you" refer to?

Ans "You" refers to the two soldiers, Luc Le Gannidec and Jean Kerderen.

c)

i) Who is the speaker?

Ans. Luc le Granidec is the speaker

ii) Why is the speaker speaking with interruption?

Ans. Luc is in a state of intense shock and grief. He has just witnessed his best friend, Jean Kerderen, fall (or jump) to his death from a bridge. His stuttering and fragmented speech reflect his emotional trauma and his difficulty processing the tragedy he just saw.

iii) What does he mean when he says "he-- fell--he fell--"?

Ans. On the surface, he is reporting an accident to his superiors. However, in the context of the story, Jean's "fall" is likely a suicide caused by the heartbreak of losing the girl they both loved to Luc. Luc uses the word "fell" to describe the physical act while perhaps trying to mask the painful truth of why it happened.

d) Two little Soldiers can be viewed as a series of dramatic scenes. Describe the story as tragedy.

Ans Two Little Soldiers is a tragedy because it follows a journey from quiet harmony to a sudden, devastating death. In the beginning, Luc and Jean share a peaceful and beautiful friendship, finding comfort in their weekly walks to the countryside. However, this happiness is destroyed when they both fall for the same girl (milkmaid). The story concludes with the "destruction" of their bond and Jean's sudden death, leaving Luc alone and haunted by his friend's loss.

The "dramatic scenes" appear like acts in a play. First, we see their silent, happy bond in the woods. Then, the tension builds as the girl enters the picture and Luc begins to see her in private. The climax happens on the bridge, where the silence between the two friends becomes unbearable.

Finally, the ending leaves the reader with a sense of pity. Jean's death feels avoidable, which makes it even more ~~pain~~ painful. He dies not in battle, but from a broken heart and a sense of betrayal by his only friend. The "harmony" of their rural escape is replaced by the cold reality of a corpse in a river.

e) What is the setting and style of the story?

Ans) The story is set between a boring military barracks and the beautiful French countryside. Every Sunday, the soldiers escape ~~that~~ their grey, disciplined lives for a small woods that reminds them of home. This setting is their "Eden", a private paradise where they feel safe. However, this beautiful backdrop makes the eventual betrayal feel much more painful because their sanctuary becomes the place where their friendship dies.

Maupassant uses a style called Naturalism, which feels like a camera recording real life. He doesn't tell us how the characters feel; he shows us through physical actions, like how they eat their bread. This "economy of style" means he strips away all the fluff. This detached tone makes the ending more shocking because the narrator remains calm while a life is being lost, leaving the reader to feel the weight.

The style is also very repetitive, mirroring the soldiers' routine. By focusing on small details - like the clinking of wine bottles - Maupassant builds a sense of realism.

f. How would you describe the conflict between the friend?

Ans. The conflict between Luc and Jean is a quiet, one-sided battle that happens in the shadows. On the surface, they stay friendly, but underneath, a wall of resentment is growing. The conflict starts with Luc's secret visits to the girl. By going behind Jean's back, Luc moves from being a partner to a rival, destroying the "all for one" bond they once shared.

Jean's internal conflict is the most painful part of the story. He feels a mix of jealousy, confusion, and deep hurt, but he doesn't know how to confront Luc. As he watches Luc and the girl get closer, Jean feels like a ghost in his own life. He is physically there during their walks, but emotionally, he has been replaced and discarded by his best friend.

Ultimately, the conflict is never resolved with words. There are no arguments or apologies. Luc's selfishness and Jean's passive nature create a toxic situation that Jean can only escape through death. The tragedy is that the conflict was preventable, but the lack of communication turned a small crush into a fatal wedge that split two 'brothers' apart forever.
